

You Can Bank On Open Source!

IDBI Bank, with its 506-branch national network, chose to explore the opportunities offered by open source software pretty early. And almost a decade later, the bank feels open source has helped reinforce its image as a customer- and technology-savvy bank.

*B*anks, like other enterprises, have opened their arms to open source-based technology for its obvious cost advantage. But talk about deploying Linux for critical applications and these very financial institutions seem to nurture numerous doubts about security, maintenance and reliability. However, back in 2003, IDBI Bank quelled all such apprehensions by placing critical applications like Oracle ERP, comprising Oracle Financials and HRMS Modules, on a Linux platform. With its roots going deeper into the open source soil, IDBI Bank's success saga remains one to learn from.

The first shoots

In 2001, IDBI Bank planted its first open source sapling by deploying Linux for its enterprise e-mail server and IVRS applications. And what prompted them to shift to open source? IDBI Bank had noticed open source technology fuelling the growth of the Internet with key applications such as the Apache Web server, the Sendmail mail transport agent, and WebStore (open source e-commerce); languages like Java and Perl; and mark-up languages like HTML, WML and XML. The bank wanted to use the potential of open source for the effective management of its processes.

"We decided to evaluate open source as it would help us lower information technology costs, implement flexible software solutions, achieve better security and get software developed using collaborative and cooperative values and not proprietary values, which would be apt for our local and organisational needs," says Sanjay Sharma, MD and CEO, IDBI Intech, a fully-owned subsidiary of IDBI Bank.

IDBI Intech provides IT-related services to the IDBI Group companies and to other organisations, focusing mainly on the BFSI sector. It provides IT services

